

1900–1920

ANTI-FASHION

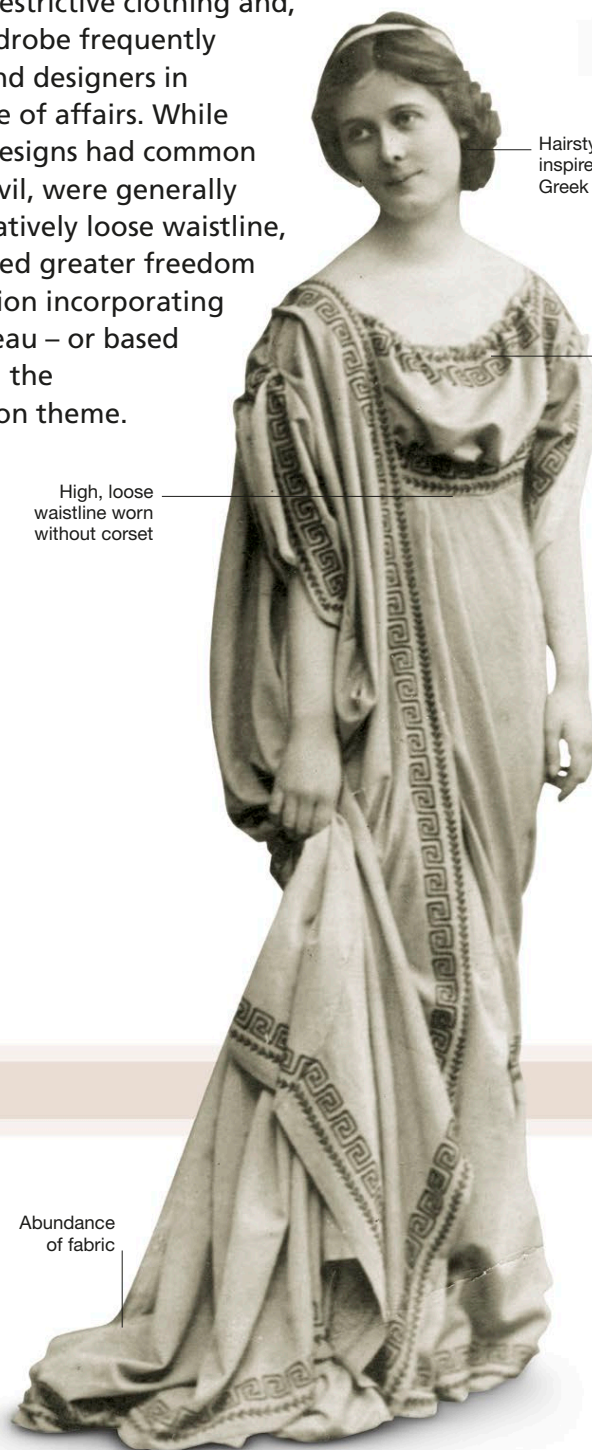
Transforming women's clothing into something more practical, timeless, "aesthetic", or all three, had been the aim of dress reformers since the 1850s, albeit without much success. Despite the introduction of specialist clothing for some physical activities, many women at the beginning of the 20th century still wore restrictive clothing and, if they could afford it, changed their wardrobe frequently according to fashion's demands. Artists and designers in several countries tried to change this state of affairs. While they proposed different solutions, their designs had common features. Corsets, seen as the root of all evil, were generally abandoned; dresses often had a high, relatively loose waistline, while voluminous sleeves and skirts allowed greater freedom of movement. Prominent surface decoration incorporating the swirling lines and motifs of Art Nouveau – or based on patterns derived from Ancient Greece, the Renaissance, or Byzantium – was a common theme.

ANNA MUTHESIUS



In 1903 German concert singer, and wife of a well-known architect and writer, Anna Muthesius published a book entitled *Das Eigenkleid der Frau* (Women's Own Dress).

Muthesius believed that dress should express the individuality of the wearer, and she urged women to break free from the fashion dictates of Paris and develop their own taste. Only then would they be able to make suitable sartorial choices and design clothes to suit themselves, using aesthetically pleasing textiles and patterns.



High, loose waistline worn without corset

Abundance of fabric

Hairstyle inspired by Greek statues

Greek key pattern



High collar reflects current fashion

Voluminous sleeves

Art Nouveau motif

1900

Art Nouveau shapes applied to hem

Art Nouveau This gown, designed by Belgian architect Henry van de Velde, was shown in a German exhibition of reform dress. Its "reception gown" label shows van de Velde was not at odds with the female custom of changing clothes throughout the day.



Appliqué decoration on hat

High waist

Stole in complementary pattern

1910

Bergfalter pattern used in two colourways

Grecian The American dancer Isadora Duncan was fascinated by Greek culture. Her gowns inspired by, but not replicating, ancient Greek clothing enabled her to dance more freely. Off the stage Duncan wore mainly fashionable dress.

Wiener Werkstätte Koloman Moser was one of the founders of the art collective Wiener Werkstätte (Vienna Workshop). Moser designed the fabric for this dress, which is cut looser than the current fashion.